militants with the requisite knowledge, or perhaps simply needed help connecting with al-Qaeda operatives already in Pakistan.

Rama offered multiple and conflicting stories about this meeting in which the person he met was/was not Reid, El Cheguer and Mokhfi were/were not present and the meeting did/did not happen. Witnesses, to whom Rama confided, said the meeting took place, and French authorities uncovered other circumstantial evidence linking Rama to Reid and suggesting on-the-ground support as well. But none of this was concrete and in the end Rama, El Cheguer and Mokhfi were convicted, for 'participation in an association of criminals with a view toward the preparation of an act of terrorism.'[207] This charge is quite broad and a person can be convicted of this crime even if unaware the people with whom he was associating, and perhaps supporting, were criminals or terrorists. It is an umbrella charge under which various different activities could fall. In this case, the French authorities were unable to prove support to Reid occurred, and instead the convictions of Rama, El Cheguer and Mokhfi resulted from their association with Lashkar.[208]

So why mention this episode? First, the nebulous nature of the case illustrates the complexities inherent in unraveling terrorist facilitation. Lashkar's transnational networks are dangerous, in part, because of the spectrum of opportunities they offer for facilitation, the difficulty to prove that this has occurred and the possibilities for elements within the organization to make use of these networks without official sanction. Providing such facilitation is also a subtle means by which Lashkar can contribute to the global jihad, and hence one that enables deniability. Second, the permutations of possible Lashkar support for an al-Qaeda attack against America must be viewed within the context of the discussions taking place within the group after 9/11 about how involved to become in the global jihad. In particular, numerous interlocutors believe there were debates over whether to continue using transnational cells only to support local operations or to expand and also use them for attacks abroad. These debates take on added resonance in light of the involvement of Lashkar operatives in attempted terrorist strikes against Australia in 2003, an operation in which the group's French connections were also involved.